CAC MASTERS SERIES

CAC. 701

FUNDAMENTALS OF COUNSELING THEORIES

MASTER IN CHILDREN AND ADOLESCENT COUNSELING

TRIUNE BIBLICAL UNIVERSITY GLOBAL EXTENSION USA

FUNDAMENTALS OF COUNSELING THEORIES

CAC. 701

Fundamentals of Counseling Theories

CAC. 701 · First Semester · 1.6 units · A complete lecture course for a sixteen-week semester

TRIUNE BIBLICAL UNIVERSITY GLOBAL EXTENSION USA

First Edition · 2026

Student Handbook of Comprehensive Lectures
Master in Children and Adolescent Counseling

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DEDICATION

To the children and young people who sit in the room and are not yet sure whether they can be helped —

and to the counsellors who learn to be worth trusting.

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About This Book

This volume is the complete lecture course for **CAC. 701 Fundamentals of Counseling Theories**, a First Semester core course of the Master in Children and Adolescent Counseling, carrying 1.6 units. It is written to be taught from and studied from without any other material in the room.

What the course is for

Every other course in the programme will teach you something to do with a child or an adolescent. This one teaches you why doing it might work, and how you would know whether it did. A counselling theory is not a belief system and not a loyalty; it is a set of answers to four hard questions — what a child is, what maintains the difficulty, by what mechanism change occurs, and what the counsellor therefore does. Answered well, those questions make practice deliberate, teachable and defensible to the parent, the school, the court or the licensing board that asks what you did and why. Answered badly or not at all, practice becomes a series of intuitive moves that cannot be evaluated and cannot be revised when they fail.

The course moves through the four great lineages of counselling theory — psychodynamic and attachment, behavioural and cognitive, humanistic and existential, systemic and family — reading each against the same four questions, and ends where practice actually lives: in the integration of competing accounts into a formulation for one particular child, held to the standard of the available evidence.

How the semester is organised

Sixteen weeks. Weeks 1 to 14 teach. Week 15 integrates: a comparative practicum in which the whole course is applied to a single extended case. Week 16 consolidates for examination. Each week is one lecture unit of about four notional hours — roughly ninety minutes of scheduled teaching, ninety minutes of seminar or practical work, and the remainder your own reading and writing. Each week has the same shape, and the shape is deliberate: outcomes you can be examined on;

the place of the week in the argument; four key concepts each tied to something a counsellor does in a room; three lectures built from propositions rather than narrative; at least one diagram placed where the argument needs one; worked examples; a practical with a debrief; seminar questions; the assessed task and its criteria; the reading, with the core text marked; and one sentence of synthesis.

A note on the child

The material is addressed throughout to work with children and adolescents, and that is not a decoration on an adult curriculum. A child cannot free-associate, may lack the vocabulary for a cognitive dispute, does not choose to attend, and is embedded in a family and a school that are themselves part of the problem and part of the solution. Theories built for adults fail in particular, predictable ways in a room with a nine-year-old. One purpose of this course is to teach you to see the failure coming.

Standards observed in this volume

British spelling in the book's own prose; American spelling preserved in quoted titles, journal names and direct quotations. Citations in APA 7th edition; only works actually cited are listed; no quotation, statistic or page number has been invented. All case material is fictitious and labelled as such; photographs generated for teaching are captioned as such; standardised instruments are described and attributed but never reproduced. Diagrams are drawn for this edition. The file is a tagged PDF conforming to PDF/UA-1. The governing specification is *HANDBOOK-STANDARD.md*, held with the series.

How to Use This Book

Read the outcomes first and last. Each week opens with what you will be able to do on completing it, written as capabilities that can be observed and examined. Read them before the week and again after it. If you cannot do what they say, you have not finished the week, however much of it you have read.

Work the examples as you meet them. Worked examples are set apart and are not optional reading. Cover the solution, attempt it, then compare. The distance between your attempt and the printed one is precisely the material the examination tests.

Do the practicals. Every week carries a practical — a timed exercise, a formulation task, a role-play, an observation or an analysis of supplied material — with a debrief. Most of them require another person or a recording of yourself and a clock. The practical is the part of the week most often skipped and the part that most changes practice. A theory you have only read is a theory you cannot use.

Keep the comparison grid. Figure 1.3 in week 1 is a blank grid: five questions down the side, four approaches across the top. Complete one column each time the course meets an approach, in your own words, and by week 15 reproduce the whole grid from memory and defend every cell. The grid is the course. Everything else is commentary on it.

Argue with the lectures. Each lecture ends in a clinical implication and a seminar question. The seminar questions are not rhetorical; write answers to them. Where a lecture states a contested position, the contest is named, and your task is to hold a position and say what would change it.

For the tutor. Each week is one four-hour block: ninety minutes of teaching, ninety minutes of seminar or practical work, the remainder preparation and follow-up. The three lectures are self-contained and may be reordered where a cohort needs the case before the theory. The assessed task printed in each week is the task set, and the criteria printed with it are the criteria used. Substitute local material in the vignette and the practical where a cohort's placements differ, provided the substitute is fictitious and labelled.

For the supervisor. The formulation exercises are yours. The question that converts knowledge into judgement is always the same: *which of the approaches in this week would formulate this case differently, and what would that formulation lead you to do on Tuesday?* A trainee who can state a mechanism of change and then say what would falsify it is ready for supervised caseload. A trainee who can only describe a theory is not.

Conventions

Convention	Meaning
Week *n*	the *n*th lecture week of the sixteen-week course
Lecture I, II, III	the three teaching sequences within a week
Worked example	a fully solved illustration; attempt it before reading the solution
Practical	a timed exercise with a debrief; requires a partner, a recording or supplied material
Hypothetical / fictitious composite	case material invented for teaching; no real client is described
Illustrative image (AI-generated)	a photograph created for this edition; depicts no identifiable person
Jurisdiction-dependent	a legal or reporting duty that must be checked against local law

Figures are numbered by week: Figure 3.2 is the second figure of week 3. Figure captions appear below the figure and table captions above the table. Every figure carries alternative text, and the file is tagged for screen readers.

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The Semester at a Glance

Sixteen weeks, one lecture unit each. Weeks 1–14 teach the course; week 15 integrates it on a single extended case; week 16 prepares the examination. The right-hand column names the assessed work of each week; the criteria for each are printed inside the week.

Week	Title	Principal lineage or task	Assessed
1	What a Theory Is For	the four questions; mechanism and technique; common factors	Comparative formulation, 1,500 words
2	The Psychodynamic Lineage I	Freud, Anna Freud, play as communication	Reading response, 600 words
3	The Psychodynamic Lineage II	attachment, the Strange Situation, the secure base	Attachment analysis of a vignette
4	The Psychodynamic Lineage III	mentalisation and reflective function	Reflective-function exercise
5	The Behavioural Lineage I	learning theory, contingency, functional analysis	Functional analysis of a case
6	The Behavioural Lineage II	cognitive therapy with children and adolescents	Cognitive formulation
7	The Behavioural Lineage III	third-wave: ACT, DBT-A, mindfulness-based work	Practical log
8	The Humanistic Lineage I	person-centred: the conditions and the child	Recorded micro-practice
9	The Humanistic Lineage II	existential and meaning work with adolescents	Essay, 1,200 words
10	The Systemic Lineage I	Bateson to Minuchin: structure,	Family map of a vignette

Week	Title	Principal lineage or task	Assessed
		boundaries, function	
11	The Systemic Lineage II	solution-focused and narrative approaches	Re-authoring exercise
12	Critique	multicultural, feminist and decolonial readings of theory	Critical review, 1,200 words
13	Integration I	case formulation across competing accounts	Formulation portfolio
14	Integration II	evidence-based practice and outcome monitoring	Outcome-measure critique
15	The Comparative Practicum	one extended case, four formulations, one recommendation	Practicum presentation
16	Revision and Examination	consolidation, past questions, examination technique	Final examination

Notional hours. 1.6 units ≈ 24 notional learning hours across the sixteen weeks, of which roughly one third is scheduled teaching and two thirds your own preparation, practice and writing. Weeks vary: the practicum week is heavier in supervised work, the revision week lighter in teaching.

Reading load. Each week marks one core text among its six readings. Read the core text before the week's teaching and the remainder across the week. The core texts of the course are Corey's *Theory and Practice of Counseling and Psychotherapy*, Geldard, Geldard and Foo's *Counselling Children*, and Weisz and Kazdin's *Evidence-Based Psychotherapies for Children and Adolescents*.

Fundamentals of Counseling Theories

SEMESTER	UNITS	CATEGORY
First	1.6	Core

Every other course in this programme will teach you something to do. This one teaches you why doing it might work, and how to tell whether it did.

A counselling theory is not a belief system and not a loyalty. It is a set of answers to a small number of hard questions: what a child is, what goes wrong, how change happens, and what the counsellor therefore does. Answered well, those questions make practice deliberate. Answered badly or not at all, practice becomes a series of intuitive moves that cannot be evaluated, cannot be taught, and cannot be defended to the parent, the school, the court or the licensing board that asks what you did and why.

The course proceeds in sixteen weeks. This week builds the frame. Weeks 2 to 4 take the psychodynamic and attachment lineage; weeks 5 to 7 the behavioural, cognitive and third-wave lineage; weeks 8 and 9 the humanistic and existential; weeks 10 and 11 the systemic, solution-focused and narrative; week 12 the critiques that keep all of them honest. Weeks 13 and 14 integrate: formulation and evidence. Week 15 runs the whole course over one extended case, and week 16 prepares you for the examination.

Throughout, the material is addressed to work with children and adolescents. That is not a decoration on an adult curriculum. A child cannot free-associate, may lack the vocabulary for a cognitive dispute, does not choose to attend, and is embedded in a family and a school that are themselves part of the problem and part of the solution. Theories built for adults fail in particular, predictable ways in a room with a nine-year-old, and one purpose of this course is to teach you to see the failure coming.

1 LECTURE UNIT 1 Teaching week 1 4 notional hours

What a Theory Is For

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this week you will be able to:

1. **State the four questions** a counselling theory must answer, and identify which of the four a given written account of a case leaves unanswered.
2. **Construct a formulation** of a fictitious case that names the presenting problem, the factors maintaining it, and the mechanism by which an intervention would change those factors.
3. **Distinguish a mechanism of change from a technique**, giving one example of each from any two of the four major approaches.
4. **Evaluate a published effectiveness claim** using three tests: what the comparison condition was, who the population was, and what was measured.
5. **Explain a theoretical position to a parent** in ordinary language, without jargon, in under two minutes.

Outcomes 1–3 are examined in this week's assessed task; outcomes 4 and 5 are examined in the practical and recur in weeks 13 and 14.

Where this week sits

This week supplies the vocabulary that the remaining fifteen argue with. Nothing here is a theory of therapy; it is a specification of what any theory of therapy has to deliver. If you learn the four questions and the distinction between mechanism and technique, you will read weeks 2 to 12 critically rather than memorising them. If you do not, they will read as twelve lists of names. Begin the comparison grid (Figure 1.3) this week and keep it to the end of the course.

Key concepts

THEORY OF CHANGE

The account a practitioner can give of *why* what they do should produce the result they want. In the room: the sentence you could say aloud after a session — "I did that because I expect it to make this difference" — and the observation that would show you were wrong. A practitioner who cannot say the sentence is not being flexible; they are being arbitrary.

FORMULATION

A written or spoken account of a particular child's difficulty that connects history, maintaining factors and context into a single argument, and implies a treatment. It is the alternative to a diagnostic label: a label tells you what category the child belongs to, a formulation tells you what to do on Tuesday. In the room: the paragraph you could hand to a colleague who has never met the child, which would let them continue the work.

MECHANISM OF CHANGE
The process inside the client through which improvement is supposed to occur — insight, extinction of a conditioned response, corrective relational experience, cognitive restructuring, altered family structure, new meaning. In the room: what you are actually counting on happening in the child's head or in the child's relationships. Techniques are what you do; the mechanism is what you are relying on the doing to cause.

FIDELITY
The degree to which what was delivered matches what the method specifies. In the room: whether you performed the intervention the manual describes, or a comfortable variation of it. Fidelity matters for two reasons that pull against each other — a method delivered loosely cannot be evaluated, and a method delivered rigidly to a child it was not designed for may be useless or harmful. Holding both thoughts at once is part of the job.

Lecture I — Theory is not optional when the client is a child

Proposition 1. A child cannot be relied upon to tell you what is wrong, so theory is the instrument that supplies hypotheses where speech is unavailable. An adult client can, at least sometimes, report a pattern: *I always leave before I am left.* A seven-year-old with the same pattern cannot. Developmental limitations of vocabulary, memory, abstraction and metacognition mean that the child's account is partial, concrete, and often an account of what adults have said about them. Theory fills the gap by generating testable hypotheses from what is observable — play, drawing, refusal, somatic complaint, behaviour in the session — and by telling you what those observations would mean if the theory were right. This is the deepest reason child counselling is theoretical in a way that adult counselling can afford not to be.

Proposition 2. Every intervention is already theoretical; the choice is between an examined theory and an unexamined one. A counsellor who says they are "not theoretical, I just build rapport" has adopted a position with a mechanism (the relationship produces change), a theory of the problem (problems persist where the child does not feel safe), and a method (be warm, be consistent, do not push). It is a person-centred position, descended from Rogers, and it is defensible. What is not defensible is holding it without knowing it, because then it cannot be revised when it fails.

Proposition 3. Theory is what makes practice evaluable. If you have stated a mechanism, then non-improvement is informative: either the mechanism did not operate, or it operated and did not produce the predicted change, or your formulation of the problem was wrong. Those are three different findings and they

lead to three different next steps. Without a stated mechanism, non-improvement is only disappointment. This is the difference between a practitioner who learns from twenty years of caseload and one who repeats one year twenty times.

Proposition 4. In work with minors, theory decides who is in the room. A behavioural theory of a child's refusal to attend school locates the problem in contingencies and will want the parents and the teacher present. A psychodynamic theory locates it in anxiety and internal conflict and may want the child alone. A systemic theory locates it in the family's organisation and will want the whole family. These are not variations in style; they are variations in who you invite, whose account you privilege, whose consent you need, and whose interest you are serving when the child's interest and the parent's interest diverge — which, in work with children, they routinely do.

> **PRACTICE NOTE**
> **Clinical implication.** Before your next case, write one sentence of the form: *I am working from the idea that this child's difficulty is maintained by X, and that Y will change it, which I would expect to see as Z.* If you cannot complete the sentence, you do not yet have a plan; you have a schedule of appointments.

Worked example 1.1 — Finding the missing question

Task. A training brochure describes a method for childhood anxiety in these terms: "Our programme uses structured play sessions in which the child externalises the worry and the counsellor guides the child to re-author the worry story. Sessions are forty-five minutes, weekly, for ten weeks. Families report high satisfaction." Which of the four questions does this account answer, and which does it leave open?

Solution. It answers question 4 (method) completely — structure, duration, frequency — and gestures at question 3 (mechanism) with "externalises" and "re-author", which implies a narrative mechanism: changing the story changes the relationship to the problem. It does not answer question 2 (maintenance): nothing is said about what keeps this child's anxiety going now, so the method cannot be matched to the case. It does not answer question 1 (view of the child) at all, so there is no statement about which children the method suits or at what developmental level "re-authoring a story" is possible — a capacity most children acquire only in middle childhood. Two questions open, one half-answered: usable as a technique, not yet as a theory.

Lecture II — The four questions

Every counselling theory, whatever its vocabulary, answers four questions. Figure 1.1 sets them out around the case they exist to explain.

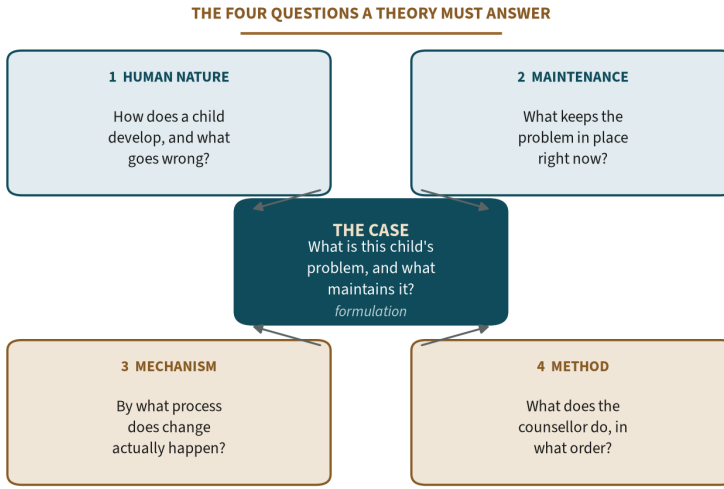


Figure 1.1 The four questions a counselling theory answers, arranged around the case: human nature, maintenance, mechanism, and method. A theory that cannot answer all four is a vocabulary rather than a treatment. *Source:* prepared for this edition.

Question 1 — Human nature and development. What is a child? A bundle of drives requiring channelled expression; an organism whose behaviour is shaped by consequence; a person with an actualising tendency that flourishes under the right conditions; a node in a communication network. Each answer determines what counts as health, and therefore what counts as the target of treatment. This question is where developmental theory enters counselling: a theory that assumes a capacity for reflection cannot be used with a child who has not developed it.

Question 2 — Maintenance. Not "how did this begin?" but "what keeps it going now?" The distinction is the most practically useful in the whole course. Origins are often unrecoverable and rarely modifiable; maintaining factors are present, observable and available to change. A child's school refusal may have begun with a bullying incident nine months ago, but it is maintained this morning by the negative reinforcement of staying home, the mother's anxious checking, the school's informal exemption from attendance, and the erosion of the child's confidence that returning is survivable. Four maintaining factors, four different intervention points, and only one of them is about the bullying.

Question 3 — Mechanism of change. Through what process does the intervention work? Insight and the making conscious of the unconscious; extinction, habituation and new learning; a corrective emotional experience within the therapeutic relationship; restructuring of the family's hierarchy and boundaries;

the construction of an alternative story. Mechanism is the question most often skipped and the one that makes a theory falsifiable: if you claim the mechanism is insight, then a treatment that produces change without insight has refuted something you believed.

Question 4 — Method. What does the counsellor do, in what order, with whom, for how long? Method is downstream of the other three, and a method adopted without them is a technique performed on a child rather than a treatment offered to one.

Two further questions are not part of every theory but should be part of every practitioner's: **what is the evidence** for this approach with this problem in this population, and **for whom** does it hold — which cultures, families, settings and languages was it developed in and tested on? The second question is taken up in week 12 and in CAC. 710; the first in week 14.

Table 1.1 shows how four approaches answer the four questions about the same presenting problem, a nine-year-old's refusal to attend school.

Table 1.1 Four answers to the same case. The differences are not stylistic; each column implies a different person to invite into the room.

Question	Psychodynamic	Behavioural / CBT	Person-centred	Systemic
View of the child	A subject with unconscious conflict and a developing internal world	A learner whose behaviour is shaped by consequences and cognitions	A person with an actualising tendency blocked by conditions of worth	A member of a system whose behaviour carries a function for it
What maintains it	Separation anxiety; unconscious meaning of school; defensive avoidance	Negative reinforcement of staying home; catastrophic cognition; safety behaviours	A relationship in which the child's experience is not accepted	Parental anxiety, enmeshment, unresolved loss, school–family coalition
Mechanism	Insight; containment; making the unconscious conscious; a reliable object	Extinction, new learning, cognitive restructuring, exposure to disconfirmation	Congruence, unconditional positive regard and empathy producing self-acceptance	Changed structure, boundaries and communication; altered function of the symptom
Method	Play, interpretation, the transference relationship, work with parents	Graded exposure, behavioural experiments, parent and teacher contingency work	Non-directive sessions, reflection, no advice, no direction	Family sessions, enactments, reframing, tasks, boundary work

PRACTICE NOTE

Clinical implication. When you read any account of a therapy — a manual, a paper, a training brochure — mark which of the four questions it answers. Marketing material for commercial programmes answers question 4 almost exclusively. That is not a reason to reject the programme; it is a reason not to mistake it for a theory.

Worked example 1.2 — Maintenance versus origin

Task. Amara, aged 11, wets the bed roughly twice a week. It began at age 5, shortly after her father left the home; her mother describes those early years as "the bad time". Current facts: Amara sleeps in her grandmother's room; the grandmother wakes her at 2 a.m. "to be safe" and changes the sheets with loud disapproval; Amara has stopped staying overnight with friends and has declined a school camp; the mother, exhausted, has begun to punish missed mornings by removing phone time. List the *maintaining* factors. Then state, for each, which family member's behaviour would have to change.

Solution. Origin: the separation at age 5 — unrecoverable and, for treatment purposes, largely irrelevant. Maintaining factors: (1) the 2 a.m. waking, which prevents Amara from learning bladder capacity and from waking to her own signals — change required: grandmother; (2) the disapproval at sheet-changing, which adds shame and anxiety, and anxiety increases enuresis risk — change required: grandmother; (3) avoidance of overnight stays, which protects Amara from discovering that the problem is manageable and from peer-normalising — change required: Amara, supported; (4) punishment of missed mornings, which converts a physiological event into a contingency and raises household stress — change required: mother. Four maintaining factors, four change agents, none of them the father who left six years ago. Note what the analysis has done: it has moved the treatment from "talk about Daddy" to four concrete, observable changes in the household's night.

Lecture III — Common factors, specific ingredients, and what the evidence actually shows

Suppose two therapies with incompatible theories of the problem and incompatible mechanisms produce the same outcomes. This happens constantly, and it is the most important empirical fact in the field. Three explanations compete.

The common factors account. Most of the variance in psychotherapy outcome is not attributable to the specific method. Lambert's widely cited decomposition attributed roughly 40 per cent of change to extratherapeutic events in the client's life, 30 per cent to relationship and expectation, 15 per cent to hope and expectancy effects, and 15 per cent to the model-specific technique; Frank and Frank made a similar argument about the healing qualities shared by

all persuasive treatments. Figure 1.2 sets the argument out. The percentages are schematic and contested — they are not measurements — but the direction of the finding has been replicated many times: what the therapist and client do together, and what happens in the client's life, matter more than which school the therapist belongs to.

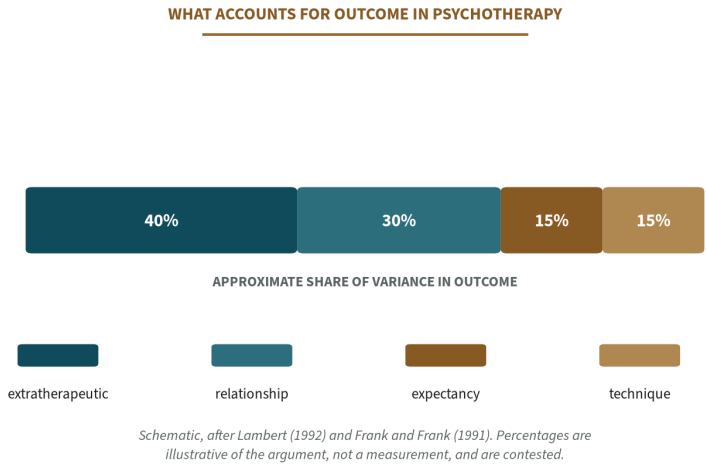


Figure 1.2 A schematic bar showing the approximate share of variance in psychotherapy outcome attributed to extratherapeutic change, relationship and expectation, hope and expectancy, and model-specific technique. Percentages are illustrative of the argument rather than a measurement, and are contested. *Source:* prepared for this edition, after Lambert (1992) and Frank and Frank (1991).

The equivalence account. The "dodo bird verdict" — that all bona fide therapies are roughly equally effective — has been argued from meta-analytic data and disputed from the same data by investigators who find reliable differences for particular disorders. Both sides are partly right, and the practical conclusion is modest: for many common presentations, differences between established therapies are small relative to differences between a competent therapy and no therapy, or between a good alliance and a poor one.

The specificity account. Some treatments do outperform others for some problems, and the clearest examples are in child and adolescent work: behavioural parent training for conduct problems, exposure-based treatment for anxiety, and trauma-focused cognitive-behavioural therapy for post-traumatic stress all have evidence that is stronger than the evidence for undifferentiated supportive counselling. Specificity is real; it is simply narrower than advocates claim.

Three consequences follow for a beginning practitioner, and they are the practical content of this lecture.

First, **the relationship is not the soft part of the work**. Alliance, empathy, agreement on goals and tasks, and the credibility of the treatment to the child and the parent are among the strongest predictors of outcome, and they are trainable. In work with children the alliance is triadic — child, parent, counsellor — and it is common for the adult alliance to be good while the child's is not, which is a serious problem that looks like success.

Second, **allegiance and depth of training matter more than choice of school**. Outcomes are better where the practitioner believes in the method and has been properly trained in it. Eclecticism adopted before competence in any single approach tends to produce drift rather than flexibility, and drift is invisible to the person drifting.

Third, **evidence-based practice is a three-legged stool, not a list**. Sackett and colleagues defined it as the integration of best available research with clinical expertise and with the patient's values and circumstances; Kazdin's distinction between evidence-based *treatments* (manualised methods that have been tested) and evidence-based *practice* (the whole process of deciding what to do with this child) is the version that matters here. A list of approved programmes answers the research leg and ignores the other two. Weisz and Kazdin's collection is the standard reference for what has actually been tested in children and adolescents.

> **PRACTICE NOTE**
> **Clinical implication.** When you read an effectiveness claim, ask three questions before you believe it: what was the comparison condition (waiting list, treatment as usual, or an active alternative)? who was the population (age, setting, comorbidity, culture — and was it children, or adults generalised downwards)? and what was measured (a rating scale completed by the parent, the teacher, the child, or an independent observer — all of which disagree more than you would expect)?

Worked example 1.3 — Reading an effectiveness claim

Task. A paper reports: "In a sample of 62 children aged 8–12 referred to a university clinic for anxiety, the new programme produced significantly greater reduction in parent-rated anxiety than a waitlist control at post-treatment ($p < .001$), maintained at three-month follow-up." Apply the three tests.

Solution. Comparison condition: waitlist. Waitlist controls answer "is this better than nothing for three months?" and almost any credible treatment is; they do not answer "is this better than an existing treatment?" Population: university-clinic referrals, which over-represent families with transport, time and confidence in institutions, and under-represent the children you will actually meet in a school or a district clinic. Measurement: parent-rated anxiety only. Parents are not blind to condition, they have an investment in the treatment having worked, and parent and child ratings of child anxiety correlate modestly at best. Verdict: the claim

supports "probably better than nothing, for anxious children of engaged families, as their parents see it" — which is not nothing, and is not what the abstract implies.

CLINICAL VIGNETTE — FICTITIOUS

Daniel — a fictitious composite. Daniel is nine. He has not attended school for eleven days. The stated reason changes: stomach ache, then a boy who looks at him, then that the work is too hard, then nothing at all. His mother sits with him each morning; his father works nights and describes Daniel as "fine, just soft". The family moved seven months ago. In the first session Daniel draws a house with no door, says "that's not for you to see", and asks twice whether his mother is still in the waiting room.

Reading 1 — attachment and internal experience. The move disrupted a peer network; the father's absence leaves the mother as the sole regulator of anxiety; Daniel's repeated checking of her presence and his doorless house suggest separation anxiety with an inhibited expression of it. The mechanism of change would be the child's experience of a reliable other and the parents' capacity to tolerate his distress. The method would include play, gentle exploration of the separation, and work with the mother's own anxiety.

Reading 2 — behavioural and cognitive. Not attending is negatively reinforced every morning: distress falls when Daniel stays home. The mother's presence is part of the reinforcement schedule. The cognition is catastrophic ("something bad will happen, and I could not cope") and is never tested because avoidance prevents disconfirmation. The mechanism would be extinction of avoidance and disconfirmation of the catastrophic belief. The method would be graded return, parent and teacher contingency work, and behavioural experiments.

Both readings fit the facts. They imply different people to invite into the room, different first sessions, and different things to count as progress. A third reading — systemic — would ask what the symptom is doing for the family, and would notice that Daniel's absence keeps a mother at home and a father's night shifts unchallenged. Daniel returns in weeks 5, 10 and 15 as the course's running case; keep your notes on him.

SKILLS LABORATORY

Practical 1 — formulation under constraint. Four timed steps, alone or in pairs, then debrief.

1. **Five minutes.** Read the vignette once. Write a single sentence: *Daniel's difficulty is maintained by* **, and** *would change it.* No theory names allowed.
2. **Ten minutes.** Write the same case twice, once from an attachment or psychodynamic position and once from a behavioural position. Each account must name a mechanism and one observation that would support it.

3. **Ten minutes.** Compare. Identify one prediction each account makes about what will happen in the next session that the other does not make. This is the test of whether you have two theories or one theory twice.
4. **Five minutes.** Role-play: explain to Daniel's mother, in ordinary language and in under two minutes, what you think is happening and what you propose to do. No jargon. She is sceptical and says, "So you just want him to talk about his feelings?"

Debrief. Which account generated a testable prediction? Which generated a description that no observation could contradict? What did the mother's question expose about your explanation?

ASSESSMENT

Assessed task. A comparative formulation of 1,500 words. You are given a second fictitious case at the end of the teaching week. Write a formulation of it from two specified theoretical positions, state each position's mechanism of change, identify the one observation that would discriminate between them, and recommend which you would act on and why.

Criterion	Weight
Each formulation names a mechanism of change, not only a description	30%
The discriminating observation is genuinely discriminating	25%
Developmental status of the child is used in the argument	20%
The recommendation is justified and its risks acknowledged	15%
APA 7th citation and prose quality	10%

Formative. Submit the one-sentence formulation from step 1 of the practical by the end of teaching week 1. Feedback is returned within five working days and is not graded.

UNIT SYNTHESIS

Synthesis. A counselling theory is a set of answers to four questions — what a child is, what maintains the difficulty, by what mechanism change occurs, and what the counsellor therefore does — and the practitioner's task is not to choose a school but to be able to state, for this child, what they are relying on and how they would know it failed.

READING (APA 7TH)

- Corey, G. (2017). *Theory and practice of counseling and psychotherapy* (10th ed.). Cengage. — **core text**; chapters 1–2 for the comparative frame used throughout this course.
- Frank, J. D., & Frank, J. B. (1991). *Persuasion and healing: A comparative study of psychotherapy* (3rd ed.). Johns Hopkins University Press.
- Kazdin, A. E. (2008). Evidence-based treatment and practice: New opportunities to bridge clinical research and practice, enhance the knowledge base, and improve patient care. *American Psychologist, 63*(3), 146–159.
- Lambert, M. J. (1992). Implications of outcome research for psychotherapy integration. In J. C. Norcross & M. R. Goldfried (Eds.), *Handbook of psychotherapy integration* (pp. 94–129). Basic Books.
- Norcross, J. C., & Lambert, M. J. (2019). Psychotherapy relationships that work III. *Psychotherapy, 56*(4), 503–515.
- Weisz, J. R., & Kazdin, A. E. (Eds.). (2017). *Evidence-based psychotherapies for children and adolescents* (3rd ed.). Guilford Press.

Seminar questions

1. A colleague says, "I don't do theory, I do what works." Reconstruct the theory they are actually using — its view of the child, its account of maintenance, its mechanism, its method — and identify one situation in which it would predictably fail.
2. If most of the variance in outcome lies outside the technique, what is the justification for training practitioners in specific models at all? Argue both sides, then take a position and state what would change it.
3. Take a case you have observed or read about and write four formulations of it, one per column of Table 1.1. Which would you act on, and what would have to be true for you to be wrong?
4. Why is the distinction between origin and maintenance ethically important as well as clinically useful, when the family believes the origin is the point?
5. What would you say to a parent who asks, "Which therapy is the best one?" Answer in the terms of this week, in under a minute.

Next week

Week 2 begins the first lineage: Freud, Anna Freud and the discovery that a child cannot be treated by the methods built for adults, and that play is the child's analytic instrument. Read the account of play as communication in Geldard, Geldard and Foo before the session, and bring one example of a child's play you have witnessed that you would call communicative and one you would not.

2 LECTURE UNIT 2 Teaching week 2 4 notional hours

The Psychodynamic Lineage I: Freud, Anna Freud, and the Child Who Cannot Free-Associate

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this week you will be able to:

1. **Explain** why the classical analytic method could not be applied to children unaltered, and state the two modifications Anna Freud and Melanie Klein each made.
2. **Describe** at least four of the therapeutic powers of play identified in the play-therapy literature, and match each to a mechanism of change.
3. **Analyse** a transcript of a child's play session using the four channels of evidence (content, relationship, symbol, regulation), producing one hypothesis per channel.
4. **Distinguish** interpretation, containment and play-as-communication as three different mechanisms, and say which a given session excerpt illustrates.
5. **State two limits** of the psychodynamic evidence base with children, and what would strengthen it.

Where this week sits

Week 1 gave you four questions. This week begins answering them with the oldest lineage in the field, and with the discovery that matters most for our programme: the child is not a small adult, and a method built for an adult's couch fails in a room with a seven-year-old. Everything later in the course — attachment in week 3, mentalisation in week 4 — grows out of the attempt to take the child's actual mind seriously.

Key concepts

THE UNCONSCIOUS, OPERATIONALLY

Not a place but a claim: that some of what a child does is organised by wishes, fears and memories they cannot report and would deny. In the room: the child who agrees to a plan on Monday and destroys it on Tuesday without knowing why. The claim is testable in a weak but real sense — a formulation built on it should predict repetitions.

DEFENCE

The mind's way of keeping unbearable material at a distance: repression, denial, projection, displacement, reaction formation, and — most visible in children —

regression. In the room: the eleven-year-old who answers every question about her parents with a detailed account of her football team. Not resistance to be broken; a solution to be respected and, slowly, made unnecessary.

PLAY AS COMMUNICATION
The child's equivalent of free association. Play is not a reward for cooperating with talk; it is the medium in which the child thinks aloud. In the room: the difference between watching what a child plays and watching *how* the child plays — who is cast in which role, what is not allowed to happen, where the story always breaks.

CONTAINMENT
The function by which an adult receives a child's unmanageable feeling, holds it without being destroyed by it or retaliating with it, and returns it in a form the child can use. In the room: what you are doing when a child's rage meets your unchanged face and unchanged schedule. Mechanism, not manner.

Lecture I — Why the classical method failed with children

Proposition 1. The classical method required capacities children do not yet have. Psycho-analysis as Freud developed it for adults depends on free association, on the capacity to observe one's own thoughts, on a sustained verbal exchange, and on a motive to understand oneself that is strong enough to survive the pain of understanding. A child of six has none of these in usable form. The child cannot lie down and say whatever comes to mind; what comes to mind arrives as play, drawing, movement and symptom.

Proposition 2. The child also arrives without a request for help. Adults come complaining of their suffering. Children are brought, usually by the person the child's symptom is most organised around. The analyst therefore meets a client who has not asked for treatment and a referrer who has. Anna Freud treated this as the central technical problem of child analysis: the analytic situation must first be made wanted, which means the analyst begins as a provider of something the child values before becoming an interpreter of anything.

Proposition 3. The child's dependence changes the ethics and the technique together. An adult can leave. A child cannot, practically or emotionally, and the analyst is always also an adult authority in a world of adult authorities. Anna Freud's conclusion — that analysis with children cannot be neutral in the way analysis with adults aims to be, and must include an educational and protective dimension — was controversial and remains correct. Klein disagreed about almost everything else but not about the gravity of the asymmetry.

Proposition 4. Two modifications followed, and they define the lineage. Anna Freud's: meet the child where the child is, build the alliance before interpreting, work closely with the parents, and interpret defence before impulse. Klein's: the child's play *is* association and can be interpreted directly, symbol by symbol, in the transference, from the first session. Between those two positions — alliance-first and interpretation-first — the whole of subsequent child psychotherapy has oscillated.

> **PRACTICE NOTE**
> **Clinical implication.** Notice which modification you instinctively prefer and why. Practitioners who cannot tolerate not-knowing drift to interpretation-first and interpret material that is not yet there. Practitioners who cannot tolerate the child's pain drift to alliance-only and never interpret at all. Both are defences; name yours.

Worked example 2.1 — Interpretation or containment?

Task. In a session, Kofi (7) spends twenty minutes building a wall of blocks around a small animal figure, then knocks the wall down, looks at you, and rebuilds it higher. He does this three times. On the fourth attempt he stops, holds the animal, and says nothing. Classify what the following three responses would each be doing: (a) "You keep making sure he's safe, and then it isn't safe enough." (b) Sitting with the silence, matching his stillness, and saying after a while, "It's a lot of work, keeping him safe." (c) Asking, "Who is the animal?"

Solution. (a) is an interpretation: it names the repetition and its meaning (safety that never becomes enough) and offers it to the child's understanding. It is well-timed only if the alliance can carry it; in session three it probably cannot, and an early interpretation is experienced as being seen through, not seen. (b) is containment with a marked mirror: the feeling is received, held, and returned in words that are his but calmer. The mechanism is regulation, not insight. (c) is neither; it is an invitation to symbolise verbally, which a seven-year-old may experience as a demand and which collapses the play into a questionnaire. For this session, (b); the interpretation (a) belongs to a later session when the repetition has been shared many times and named by the child first.

Lecture II — Play as the analytic instrument

If play is association, then the playroom is a text and the counsellor is a reader. Schaefer and Drewes organise the therapeutic powers of play into four groups: communication, emotional healing, social competence and personal strength. Four are worth learning first because each carries a mechanism.

Play communicates what cannot be said. A child's narrative choices — who is powerful, who is helpless, who is absent, what is not allowed to occur — carry

material the child cannot report. The mechanism is expression: material that is enacted is material that can be responded to.

Play regulates affect at a survivable dose. In play the child controls the distance to the frightening thing. The monster is in the box; the box is closed; the child opens it when ready. The mechanism is graduated exposure under the child's own control, which is why play therapy can be effective for anxiety and post-traumatic material without ever becoming a protocol.

Play allows the forbidden in symbolic form. Wishes that would be dangerous to express directly — to destroy the rival, to abandon the parent — can be expressed by a proxy and survive the expression. The mechanism is displacement with safety: the impulse is discharged and observed without consequence.

Play rehearses mastery. The child who was helpless becomes, in play, the one who rescues, decides, repairs. The mechanism is enactment of the counterposition: competence practised where failure costs nothing.

Figure 2.2 sets out the four channels through which the playroom yields evidence, and the discipline that keeps the reading honest.

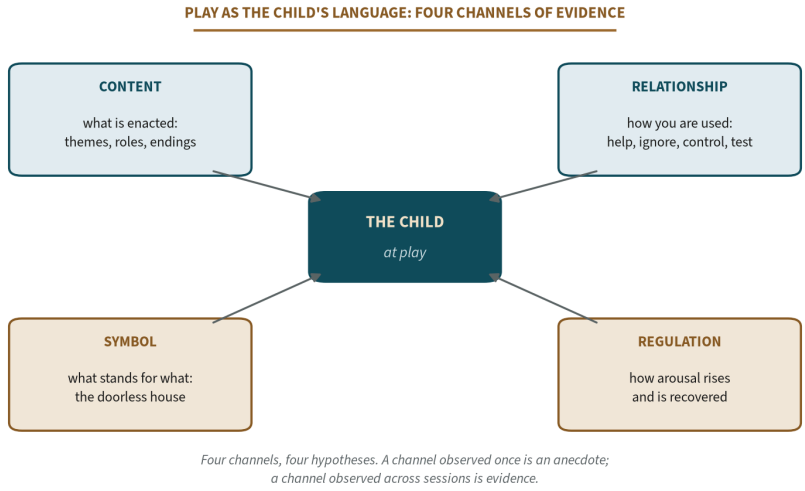


Figure 1.3 Play as the child's language: four channels of evidence — content, relationship, symbol and regulation — each yielding a hypothesis about the child rather than a conclusion. A channel observed once is an anecdote; a channel observed across sessions is evidence. *Source:* prepared for this edition.

SAFEGUARDING AND DUTY TO REPORT

Play therapy with children routinely surfaces disclosures of harm. A child who enacts violence against a doll, or sexualised play beyond developmental expectation, may be communicating abuse. Play content is not in itself evidence and must never

> be over-read; but a disclosure in a session — spoken or enacted and then spoken — engages your safeguarding duty immediately. Follow the procedure of your jurisdiction and placement, record what was said and done in the child's words, and do not interrogate the child to strengthen an account. See CAC. 703 for the full framework; the duty is assumed from this week forward.

Lecture III — The structural and topographic map, and what survives of it

Freud's map of the mind — conscious, preconscious, unconscious; id, ego, superego — is now mostly of historical interest as a model of cognition, and no serious practitioner reads a child's mind through it literally. Three of its claims, however, survive in modern form and are worth keeping.

First, that much of mental life is not available to report. Cognitive science has absorbed this without the hydraulics: implicit memory, automatic appraisal, procedural knowledge of relationships. When a psychodynamic clinician says a child's internal working model is unconscious, the claim is close to what attachment research means by implicit relational knowledge.

Second, that the mind manages conflict by distance. Defence is now studied as emotion regulation strategy, and the developmental sequence of defences maps recognisably onto the developmental sequence of regulatory strategies.

Third, that early relationships become structure. This is the claim that attachment theory operationalised and tested, and it is the bridge to next week.

Figure 2.1 shows the classical map as the lineage states it, with the modern gloss attached. Read it as the lineage's self-description, not as current cognitive science.

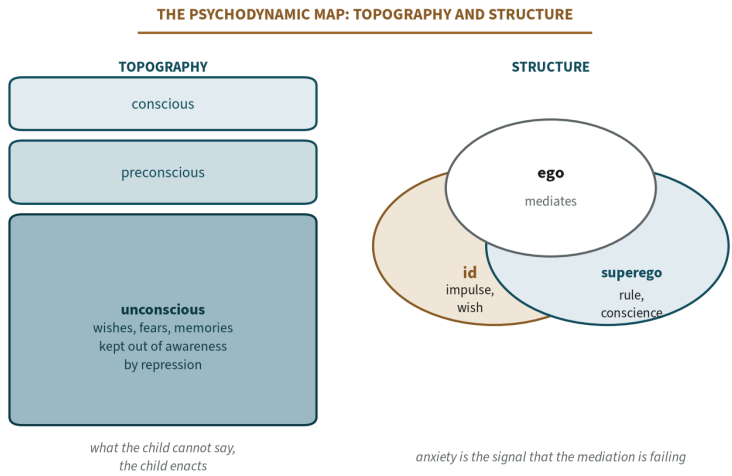


Figure 1.4 The psychodynamic map in two panels: topography as depth layers of conscious, preconscious and unconscious, and structure as the mediating ego between impulse and rule, with anxiety as the signal of failed mediation. Read as the lineage's self-description rather than as current cognitive science. *Source:* prepared for this edition.

PRACTICE NOTE

Clinical implication. The evidence base for psychodynamic therapy with children is thinner than for behavioural and cognitive methods: fewer randomised trials, smaller samples, and outcome measures that privilege the theory. Midgley and colleagues' work on child psychotherapy outcome is the honest state of the art. This does not make the lineage useless; it makes it a lineage whose claims you must hold as hypotheses. The capacities it names — containment, symbolic expression, the repetition of relational patterns — are observable in every session whatever your school, and every school borrows them.

Worked example 2.2 — Four channels, four hypotheses

Task. Read the following excerpt from a fictitious session with Ama (6), referred after her mother's new partner moved in. Ama plays with a family of dolls. She seats the mother doll and the baby doll together, then places the father doll on a shelf facing the wall. A large dog doll enters and knocks over the baby doll. Ama right the baby, puts the dog outside the house, then brings the dog back in and seats it at the table. She looks at you and says, "He's not bad. He's just big." Produce one hypothesis per channel.

Solution. *Content:* the recurring sequence is intrusion, damage, repair, and re-admission — the new partner damages and is nevertheless seated at the table; hypothesis: the child is working out whether the intrusion can be made safe rather

than expelled. *Relationship:* Ama looks at you before naming the dog's goodness; hypothesis: she is testing whether you will agree that the big thing can be good, i.e. whether loyalty to the absent father will be punished here. *Symbol:* the father doll faces the wall — excluded but present, watching; hypothesis: the child holds the father as observer of the new arrangement, and guilt about enjoying the new partner may be part of the problem. *Regulation:* arousal rises at the knock and falls at the re-seating; the play recovers without your help; hypothesis: regulatory capacity is intact and the play is mastery rather than overwhelm. Four hypotheses, none a conclusion; next week's sessions test them.

SKILLS LABORATORY

Practical 2 — the playroom transcript. In pairs. One partner plays a six-minute "session" with any available objects while the other observes and notes only observable events (what is chosen, what happens to it, who is cast where, where the story breaks, where arousal rises and falls). Then the observer produces four hypotheses, one per channel, each marked with the observation it rests on and one observation that would disconfirm it. Swap. Debrief on the discipline: how many of your first instincts survived being written as testable hypotheses?

ASSESSMENT

Assessed task. A play-analysis of 1,000 words on a supplied fictitious session transcript: four channel-hypotheses, the mechanism each implies, and a statement of what you would do in the next session and why.

Criterion	Weight
Each hypothesis is tied to a named observation	35%
Mechanisms distinguished from descriptions	25%
Disconfirming observation offered for each	20%
Next-session plan follows from the hypotheses	10%
APA 7th and prose quality	10%

Formative. Bring one example of play you have witnessed that you would call communicative and one you would not, with a sentence on the difference.

UNIT SYNTHESIS

Synthesis. The psychodynamic lineage's durable contribution is the claim that the child's mind must be met in the child's medium — play, symbol and relationship — and that what cannot be said can still be observed, held and, in time, understood.

READING (APA 7TH)

- A. Freud. (1946). *The psycho-analytical treatment of children* (2nd ed.). International Universities Press.
- Axline, V. M. (1947). *Play therapy: The inner dynamics of childhood*. Houghton Mifflin.
- Geldard, K., Geldard, D., & Foo, R. Y. (2018). *Counselling children: A practical introduction* (5th ed.). SAGE. — **core text**; the play-therapy chapters.
- Klein, M. (1932). *The psycho-analysis of children*. Hogarth.
- Midgley, N., & Kennedy, E. (2011). Psychodynamic psychotherapy for children and adolescents: A critical review of the evidence base. *Journal of Child Psychotherapy, 37*(3), 277–300.
- Schaefer, C. E., & Drewes, A. A. (2011). *The therapeutic powers of play: 20 core agents of change* (2nd ed.). Wiley.
- Winnicott, D. W. (1971). *Playing and reality*. Tavistock.

Seminar questions

1. Anna Freud insisted on building the alliance before interpreting; Klein interpreted from the first session. What does each position assume about the child's capacity to bear being understood?
2. Is containment a mechanism or a manner? Defend your answer with an observation that would distinguish the two.
3. A parent asks why their child "just plays" in sessions. Compose your reply in ordinary language, and identify the mechanism you are claiming.
4. What would count as evidence that symbolic play, rather than the relationship, produced a change?
5. Where is the line between reading a symbol and imposing one? Give an example of an over-reading you have seen or made.

Next week

Week 3 moves from the drive model to the relational one: Bowlby's attachment theory, the Strange Situation, and the secure base. Read the description of the Strange Situation procedure and the four categories before the session; bring one example from your own observation of a child using an adult as a safe haven and one of a child not doing so.

3 LECTURE UNIT 3 Teaching week 3 4 notional hours

The Psychodynamic Lineage II: Attachment, the Strange Situation, and the Secure Base

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this week you will be able to:

1. **Describe** the Strange Situation procedure and the four attachment categories it yields, including what each category's behaviour is organised around.
2. **Explain** the secure-base cycle and identify, in a given case, the point at which the cycle breaks.
3. **Use** the concepts of internal working model, safe haven and secure base to formulate one case, distinguishing them from each other.
4. **Evaluate** two limits of attachment-based practice: the gap between infant categories and later personality, and the risk of using "attachment" as an untestable explanation.
5. **State** why disorganised attachment matters clinically and what it obliges the practitioner to do differently.

Where this week sits

Week 2 ended with the claim that early relationships become structure. This week examines the research programme that tested that claim and made it measurable. Attachment theory is the psychodynamic lineage's most durable gift to practice with children, and also its most over-used word: "attachment" is invoked to explain everything from clinginess to arson. By the end of this week you should be able to use the concept precisely, and to notice when others are not.

Key concepts

ATTACHMENT BEHAVIOUR

Behaviour whose predictable outcome is proximity to a particular person under conditions of fear, fatigue or illness — crying, following, clinging, reaching. It is a behavioural system with a function, not a sentiment. In the room: the child who checks whether mother is in the waiting room is running attachment behaviour; the child who does not check may be running it too, in the deactivating form.

SAFE HAVEN AND SECURE BASE

Two directions of one relationship. The safe haven is who the child goes to when frightened; the secure base is who the child goes *from* when exploring. In the room: a child who has neither will not play, because play requires confidence that the world can be left and returned to.

INTERNAL WORKING MODEL

The child's accumulated, largely implicit expectations of what happens when need is expressed: whether the signal will be answered, and how. In the room: the reason

two children respond identically to your warmth with opposite meanings — one relieved, one suspicious.

SENSITIVITY
The caregiver's capacity to notice the child's signal, read it correctly, and respond promptly and appropriately. Not love, not commitment, not resources: accuracy and timing. In the room: the variable you are actually working on in most parenting-focused work.

Lecture I — From drive to relationship: what Bowlby changed

Proposition 1. Attachment is not a derivative of feeding. The psychoanalytic and learning traditions both derived the child's tie to the mother from the satisfaction of hunger. Bowlby's argument, built on ethology and on the observation of separated children, was that the tie is primary: proximity-seeking is its own system with its own function, the protection of the immature organism. Harlow's work with infant monkeys — preference for the cloth surrogate over the wire one that fed them — made the point unanswerable, though its method would not be permitted today and is cited here as history.

Proposition 2. Separation has an observable sequence. Observation of young children separated from a parent showed protest, then despair, then detachment — and that detachment, the apparent recovery, is the most worrying phase, because it is the child's solution to an unbearable situation and it generalises. Robertson's films of hospitalised children changed practice in hospitals and, eventually, in courts and care systems.

Proposition 3. The Strange Situation made the theory measurable. Ainsworth's procedure — a series of separations and reunions with a stranger in an unfamiliar room — compresses the attachment system into twenty minutes and makes the reunion observable. What is coded is not the separation distress but the *organisation of behaviour at reunion*: how the child resolves the conflict between the wish for comfort and whatever else the relationship has taught.

Proposition 4. Four organisations, not four temperaments. In the secure pattern (B) distress is signalled and comfort accepted, and play resumes. In the avoidant pattern (A) the signal is minimised: the child looks fine and is not, physiologically. In the resistant pattern (C) the signal is maximised and comfort does not settle it. In the disorganised pattern (D), added later by Main and Solomon, there is no coherent strategy: the child approaches and freezes, stills, or shows contradictory behaviour, because the person who would be the solution is also, in some way, the source of alarm. Figure 3.1 places the four on the two dimensions the procedure measures.

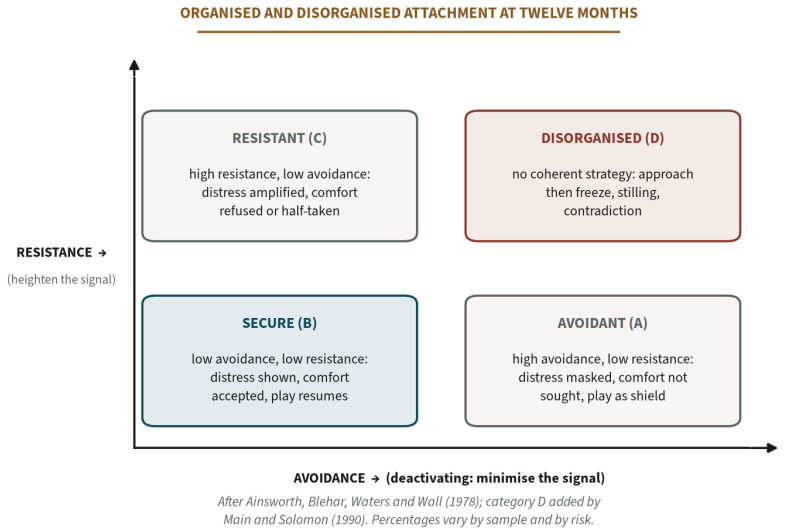


Figure 1.5 Organised and disorganised attachment at twelve months plotted on avoidance and resistance: secure low on both, avoidant high avoidance, resistant high resistance, disorganised without a coherent strategy. After Ainsworth, Blehar, Waters and Wall (1978), with category D added by Main and Solomon (1990). *Source:* prepared for this edition.

PRACTICE NOTE

Clinical implication. A is not "cold", C is not "manipulative", D is not "naughty". Each category is the best organisation the child could build with the caregiver available. When you feel moral judgement rising toward a child's strategy, you have stopped formulating.

Worked example 3.1 — Reading a reunion

Task. A nursery records a reunion on video for a settling-in assessment. Tunde (14 months) continues playing when his mother leaves, does not look up when she returns, and turns his body away while reaching briefly toward her, the reach abandoned. His heart rate, measured in a research context, rose at separation. Classify, and say what the classification implies about the household.

Solution. The pattern is avoidant (A): distress at separation (physiological), minimised signalling at reunion, attention turned to objects, an aborted approach. The implication is not that the mother is unloving but that bids for comfort have, repeatedly, not been answered or have been answered with rejection, so the child has organised around not bidding. Intervention targets the caregiver's response to distress signals, not the child's "independence", which is the strategy and not the problem. Note the trap: to an untrained observer

Tunde looks settled and easy. Avoidant children are frequently described as "good babies".

Lecture II — The secure-base cycle in practice

Figure 3.2 draws the cycle the whole lineage is trying to protect: exploration out, signal when threatened, safe haven, co-regulation, and out again. Three clinical uses follow.

First, as an assessment frame. For any child, ask four questions: who is the safe haven, is the haven actually safe, what happens to the signal on the way to the haven, and what happens to exploration afterwards. A child in care may have a haven on paper and none in fact; a child whose haven responds inconsistently will signal loudly (C); a child whose haven punishes signalling will not signal at all (A); a child whose haven is frightening will show no workable strategy (D).

Second, as a treatment target. Most parenting-focused interventions — including the behavioural parent training of week 5 and the dyadic work of CAC. 728 — can be described as repairs to one segment of the cycle: helping the caregiver notice the signal (sensitivity), tolerate the distress (co-regulation), or survive the reunion (repair after rupture). Naming the segment tells you which sessions to run.

Third, as an account of what the counsellor is. With an avoidant child you will be tested by apparent indifference; with a resistant child by protest that does not settle; with a disorganised child by fear of you. The counsellor's task is to become a predictable segment of the cycle without pretending to replace the caregiver — a temporary secure base whose job is to make the real one usable again.

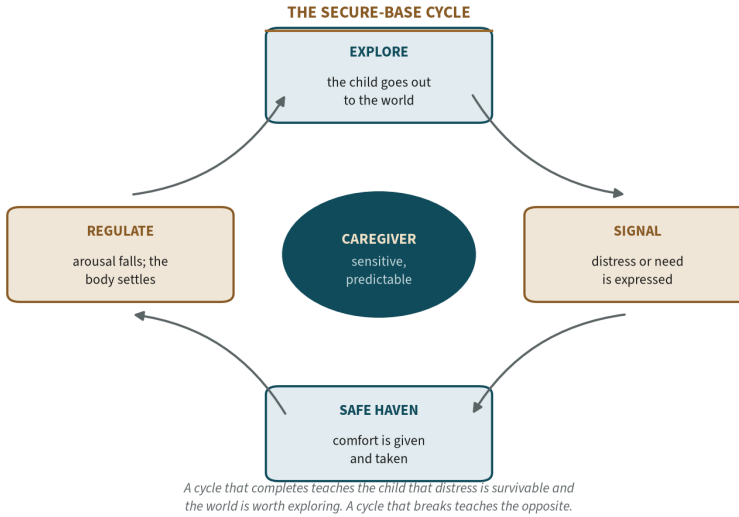


Figure 1.6 The secure-base cycle: exploration, signal, safe haven and regulation, arranged around a sensitive and predictable caregiver; a cycle that completes teaches the child that distress is survivable and the world worth exploring, a cycle that breaks teaches the opposite. *Source:* prepared for this edition.

> **SAFEGUARDING AND DUTY TO REPORT**
> Disorganised attachment is strongly associated with caregiving that is frightening, frightened or frighteningly absent, and therefore with maltreatment. Where a child shows fear without solution toward a caregiver — freezing, stilling, approach-avoidance in the same moment — treat it as a safeguarding indicator requiring assessment of the caregiving environment, not merely as a treatment consideration. Follow your jurisdiction's and placement's procedure.

Lecture III — What attachment theory does not say

Three over-extensions are common in practice and in court reports, and you should not repeat them.

The category is not a personality. Infant attachment categories predict group-level outcomes modestly and probabilistically; they are not diagnoses of the child's character, and a B classification at twelve months is not a warranty. The Minnesota longitudinal study shows the predictive power of early care operating largely *through* subsequent care and circumstance: early patterns matter, and later experience keeps mattering.

"Attachment disorder" is not the same thing as insecure attachment. The clinical diagnoses of reactive attachment disorder and disinhibited social engagement disorder describe rare patterns associated with severe early neglect

and institutional care. They are not labels for difficult behaviour in looked-after children generally, and their casual use has real consequences for the child labelled.

The mother is not the only attachment figure, and attachment is not the only relationship that matters. Children build hierarchies of attachment figures including fathers, grandparents and older siblings, and their development depends on many relationships besides attachment ones — teaching, friendship, mentorship. A formulation that reduces a child's difficulties to "attachment" has usually stopped looking.

> **PRACTICE NOTE**
> **Clinical implication.** When a report states that a child has an "attachment problem", ask three questions: on what observation, using what procedure, against what comparison? If the answer is "the child clings to me", the report has described a behaviour and named a theory over it.

Worked example 3.2 — Where the cycle breaks

Task. Zainab (4) is in foster care, third placement in fourteen months. In the current placement she is described as "indiscriminately affectionate": she sits on the foster carer's lap within minutes of meeting visitors, calls strangers "mummy", and shows no preference for the carer at reunion after nursery. Name the segment of the cycle that is broken, the hypothesis it supports, and the first thing you would do.

Solution. The broken segment is the specificity of the safe haven: the signal is dispatched to anyone, which means it has never been reliably answered by anyone in particular. The hypothesis is not "too much attachment" but the absence of an organised attachment relationship — the pattern associated with disinhibited social engagement, and a pointer to the quality of early care rather than to the current carer's adequacy. The first thing to do is not to work with Zainab's sociability but to stabilise the placement and work with the carer on being predictably, specifically available: the cycle cannot be repaired with a different adult every quarter. Note what the formulation prevents — a misreading of the child's friendliness as health, and a misreading of the carer as unloved and therefore failing.

> **SKILLS LABORATORY**
> **Practical 3 — the cycle audit.** Using a case you know professionally or a supplied vignette, draw the secure-base cycle for the child: name the safe haven(s), mark where the signal goes, what happens to it on the way, what the haven does with it, and what happens to exploration afterwards. Mark the break. Then write one sentence of intervention aimed only at the broken segment. Compare with a partner: did you both mark the same break? If not, what observation settles it?

ASSESSMENT

Assessed task. A cycle audit and formulation of 1,200 words on a supplied case: the four assessment questions answered from the material, the broken segment named, an intervention aimed at that segment, and a statement of what the formulation does not explain.

Criterion	Weight
The four assessment questions answered from observed material	30%
Broken segment identified and justified	25%
Intervention matched to the segment	20%
Limits of the formulation stated	15%
APA 7th and prose quality	10%

Formative. Submit one example of a child using an adult as a safe haven and one of a child not doing so, each with the observation it rests on.

UNIT SYNTHESIS

Synthesis. Attachment theory gives practice a measurable relational grammar — signal, haven, base, model — and its discipline is as important as its content: a category is an observation under a procedure, never a personality, and "attachment" explains less than it is asked to explain.

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Seminar questions

1. Why is the reunion, rather than the separation, the coded event in the Strange Situation? What does that choice assume about what attachment is?
2. An avoidant child is described by a teacher as "independent and easy". Rewrite the description in the lineage's terms and state what the rewrite changes about how the child should be taught.
3. Under what conditions, if any, should a counsellor become a child's attachment figure? Argue against your own answer.
4. A court report states that a child's difficult behaviour "is caused by disorganised attachment". What is missing from the sentence, and how would you test it?
5. What does attachment theory owe to the psychodynamic lineage, and what did it have to abandon from that lineage to become testable?

Next week

Week 4 completes the lineage with the concept that connects attachment to practice: mentalisation — the capacity to treat oneself and others as beings with minds, and the caregiver function that builds it. Read the description of marked mirroring before the session and bring one example of an adult responding to a child's feeling in a way that made it worse.

4 LECTURE UNIT 4 Teaching week 4 4 notional hours

The Psychodynamic Lineage III: Mentalisation and the Mind That Holds Minds

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this week you will be able to:

1. **Define** mentalisation and distinguish it from empathy, theory of mind and insight.
2. **Describe** the three pre-mentalising modes — psychic equivalence, pretend mode and teleological stance — and identify each in a transcript.
3. **Explain** marked mirroring and state what makes a mirror "marked", using an example.
4. **Apply** the mentalising loop to a session excerpt, locating the point at which the loop broke and whose mind it broke in.
5. **Use** one measure of parental reflective functioning to structure an assessment interview, stating its limits.

Where this week sits

Weeks 2 to 4 are one argument. Week 2: the child's mind must be met in the child's medium. Week 3: the child's expectations of minds are built in early relationships and are measurable. Week 4: the capacity that those relationships build is the capacity to think about minds at all — your client's, yours, and eventually the child's own. Mentalisation is the mechanism the psychodynamic lineage proposes for its own effectiveness, and it is the bridge by which the lineage joins modern developmental science.

Key concepts

MENTALISING
The imaginative activity of perceiving and interpreting behaviour in terms of mental states — wants, feelings, beliefs, intentions — in oneself and in others. Not empathy (feeling with), not theory of mind (the developmental capacity tested in false-belief tasks), not insight (understanding one's own history). In the room: the difference between "he hit me because he is bad" and "he hit me because he thought I was going to leave him".

MARKED MIRRORING
The caregiver's response that shows the child's feeling accurately but not identically — the face says *your* fear, slightly stylised, contained, and survivable, not the adult's own fear. In the room: the tone you use when a child screams — matching enough to be recognised, modulated enough to be bearable. Unmarked mirroring (the adult's real alarm) teaches the child that the feeling is as dangerous as it feels.

REFLECTIVE FUNCTION
The measurable individual difference in the capacity to mentalise, assessed by coding how a person talks about minds — in the Adult Attachment Interview for adults, in the Parent Development Interview for parents about their child. In the room: what you are listening for when a parent says "he knows exactly how to wind me up" (teleological, no mind) versus "I think he provokes me because he's waiting for me to prove I'll stay" (a mind imagining a mind).

PRE-MENTALISING MODES
The ordinary, developmental, and regressed ways of relating to inner reality before or instead of mentalising: **psychic equivalence** (inner is outer; the thought is the thing, so the fear is a fact); **pretend mode** (inner is severed from outer; talk about feelings that changes nothing); **teleological** (only physical outcomes count; only what you *did* proves what you feel). In the room: the three ways a session stalls.

Lecture I — What mentalisation is and is not

Proposition 1. Minds are opaque, and everything social rests on an inference. You cannot observe a child's fear; you observe a face, a posture, a refusal, and you infer. Mentalising is the inference run deliberately, with the knowledge that it is an inference. The non-mentalising error is not the inference but the certainty.

Proposition 2. The capacity is developmental and state-dependent. Children acquire mental-state understanding in a predictable sequence through the preschool years, and the capacity is fragile under arousal: a child — or an adult — who can mentalise calmly cannot do so in panic. Most ruptures in sessions with children are not failures of skill but collapses of mentalising under threat, in the child or in you.

Proposition 3. Mentalising is what the caregiver builds, and play is where it is built. When a caregiver treats the child as a being with a mind — naming, wondering, getting it wrong and correcting — the child acquires the same stance toward themselves. Fonagy and colleagues' proposal is that the child's sense of self as a thinking being is internalised marked mirroring: the child finds their own mind in the caregiver's face, stylised and survivable.

Proposition 4. Psychopathology can be read as a collapse into pre-mentalising modes. In psychic equivalence the anxious child's prediction is a fact and reassurance is a lie; in pretend mode the adolescent's therapy talk is fluent and weightless; in the teleological stance the neglected child reads love only in what is done and bought, and tests you with demands that cannot be satisfied because they ask for proof of a mind. Figure 4.1 draws the loop whose failure produces these states.

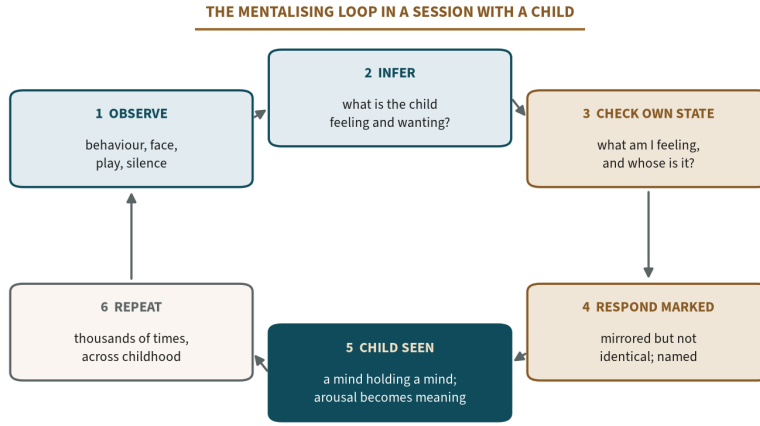


Figure 1.7 The mentalising loop in a session with a child: observe behaviour, infer the child's mental state, check one's own state, respond marked and contingent, so that the child experiences a mind holding a mind and arousal becomes meaning; the loop repeats across childhood. *Source:* prepared for this edition.

PRACTICE NOTE

Clinical implication. When a session stops working, ask first which mode you are both in. Interpreting to a child in psychic equivalence escalates: your interpretation is experienced as an external fact to be fought. The repair is regulation first, mentalising second, interpretation last.

Worked example 4.1 — Naming the mode

Task. Classify each utterance and say what the practitioner's next move should be. (a) Chidi (8), after a nightmare: "The man is in the house. You didn't lock the door properly." (b) Bisi (15), in week six of counselling: "Yeah, I see how my avoidance maintains the anxiety, it's the negative reinforcement cycle," delivered flatly, with no change in any behaviour. (c) Emeka (10), to a foster carer: "If you loved me you would have bought the phone like I asked."

Solution. (a) Psychic equivalence: the dream-content is reality; reassurance ("there is no man") will be heard as dishonesty or stupidity. Next move: take the fear seriously as an experience without confirming the fact — "in the dream he was absolutely in the house; that is what fear does, it makes what it fears real" — then regulate, then explore. (b) Pretend mode: the vocabulary is present and the mind is absent; the therapy has become a seminar. Next move: stop teaching the model and ask what happened this week when the cycle actually ran; bring the discussion back to a specific, felt moment. (c) Teleological: love is only what is

done; the demand is a test of mind, and satisfying it proves nothing because only the object was offered. Next move: do not buy the phone and do not refuse it coldly; name what is being asked for — "you want to know I would do things for you; the phone can't answer that, but I can tell you what I notice about you" — and survive the disappointment without retaliation.

Lecture II — The loop in the room, and where it breaks

Figure 4.1 is a description of ordinary good care, not a technique. Six steps, run thousands of times: observe; infer the child's state; check your own state (whose fear is this?); respond marked and contingent; the child experiences being seen by a mind; repeat. Four failure points are worth memorising because each has a different repair.

Failure at observation. You did not see it — the micro-turn away, the change in play. Repair is ordinary attention and, where possible, video or supervision: practitioners systematically overestimate what they noticed.

Failure at inference. You saw it and read it wrong, usually by reading your own state into the child. Repair is the habit of offering the inference as a question and being willing to be corrected by a nine-year-old, which is one of the most mentalising things an adult can do.

Failure at self-check. Your own alarm or anger enters the response unmarked, and the child meets your state instead of their own. This is the failure that most often ends placements and therapeutic relationships. Repair is supervision and the discipline of naming your state before you act on it.

Failure at marking. The response is accurate but unmodulated — a mirror without a frame — or modulated into falseness, which children detect instantly. Repair is practice: the marked response is a skill with a feel to it, learned by being marked oneself.

> **SAFEGUARDING AND DUTY TO REPORT**
> Mentalising failure is a safeguarding concept as well as a clinical one. Caregiving that is frightening, frightened or persistently unmarked — the carer whose face shows their own terror or rage in response to the child's distress — is both a cause of disorganised attachment and an indicator of risk in the home. Where you observe it, it is reportable material under your safeguarding procedure, not merely a formulation.

Lecture III — Measuring reflective function, and using it without abusing it

Reflective function is coded from interview: the Parent Development Interview asks parents to describe their child and their relationship, and the coding counts evidence that the parent treats the child as a mind — recognising opacity, wondering about states, tracking change, acknowledging the limits of their own

knowledge. Parents high in reflective function have, on average, children with better regulation and fewer difficulties; the association holds over and above income and education, and interventions that raise parental reflective function show effects on parenting and on child outcomes in several trials.

Two cautions govern its use in practice. First, the measures are research instruments requiring training; a clinician who "assesses reflective function" by impression is not measuring anything. Second, low reflective function is not moral failure and not a verdict on love: it is often the residue of a childhood in which nobody mentalised the parent, and it is treatable. The clinical use of the concept is not to sort parents but to decide what to do: with a parent in teleological mode, behavioural work and concrete tasks first, mentalising later; with a parent able to wonder, formulation work can begin immediately.

Mentalisation-based work with adolescents — including the adaptations for self-harm and for borderline presentation in adolescence — applies the same loop to the therapeutic relationship: the therapist's job is to keep mentalising when the adolescent cannot, to mark their own reactions, and to treat every rupture as material about minds rather than as misbehaviour. That stance, more than any technique, is what the lineage hands to the rest of this course.

> **PRACTICE NOTE**
> **Clinical implication.** Adopt one habit from this week and keep it for the rest of the programme: before you respond to a child's strongest feeling, name silently (1) what you think the child is feeling, (2) what you are feeling, and (3) one alternative reading of the child's state. Three seconds. It is the cheapest intervention in the course.

Worked example 4.2 — The rupture as material

Task. In session eight, Funke (12), who has begun to trust you, arrives and announces that the sessions are stupid and she is not coming back. Last session she disclosed something shameful and you responded well, or so you thought. Using the loop, formulate the rupture and plan your response.

Solution. Observe: the announcement follows the disclosure; the timing is the datum. Infer: the shame of having been seen has reorganised as contempt for the seer; the prediction inside her is that you now think less of her, and leaving first converts rejection into choice. Check your own state: you feel stung and, underneath, defensive — the pull to point out her progress, which would be your state, not hers. Respond marked: neither collapse ("of course you can stop") nor defence ("after everything we've done"); instead, naming the sequence as a hypothesis about minds — "last week you told me something hard, and today the sessions are stupid; I wonder if being seen here has started to feel dangerous." The loop's repair is the demonstration that your mind survived her feeling and still

holds an image of her that includes last week's courage. What you must not do is treat the announcement as a decision to be negotiated; it is not a decision, it is a mental state.

SKILLS LABORATORY

Practical 4 — the three-second habit and the marked response. In triads. One plays a child delivering a high-arousal statement (supplied cards: "I hate you", "You're just like my mum", "Nothing works, nothing ever works", "It's not a big deal, stop looking at me like that"). The responder has three seconds to name silently the child's state, their own state, and one alternative reading, then delivers a marked response of one sentence. The third member codes: was the response marked (accurate but modulated), unmarked (the responder's own state), or false (modulated into nothing)? Rotate. Debrief: which statements pulled you into which failure?

ASSESSMENT

Assessed task. A rupture analysis of 1,000 words on a supplied transcript: locate the break in the loop, name the mode each party is in, write the marked response you would give, and state what you would watch for in the next session to know whether the repair worked.

Criterion	Weight
Break located with the observation it rests on	30%
Modes named for both parties	25%
Marked response is marked (accurate, modulated, contingent)	25%
Repair criterion specified for the next session	10%
APA 7th and prose quality	10%

Formative. Submit one example of an adult responding to a child's feeling in a way that made it worse, analysed in terms of marking.

UNIT SYNTHESIS

Synthesis. Mentalisation is the psychodynamic lineage's account of its own mechanism — a mind holding a mind until the child can hold their own — and its practical gift is a discipline: under arousal, regulate first, mentalise second, interpret last.

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Seminar questions

1. Distinguish mentalising from empathy with an example in which the two come apart, and say which the child needs in a crisis.
2. Why is unmarked mirroring harmful? Give the mechanism in the lineage's own terms and in regulatory terms.
3. A parent says, "He does it to annoy me." Rewrite the sentence at three levels of reflective function and say what each version implies for treatment.
4. Under what arousal conditions does your own mentalising fail, and what is your personal repair? Answer from observation, not aspiration.
5. Is mentalisation-based practice a theory or a stance? What turns on the answer?

Next week

Week 5 changes lineage: from minds to contingencies. Learning theory, functional analysis and the behavioural account of the child's problem. Read the description of the ABC (antecedent–behaviour–consequence) sequence and bring one example of a child's behaviour that is maintained by the very response that punishes it.

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